

# Female Reservation and the Qualifications of Local Elected Officials in India

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Working draft

## Abstract

We examine how the qualifications of local elected officials differ between women-reserved and open seats. We compare winners of women-reserved and open seats in rural councils in Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan and Kerala and in the municipal councils of Mumbai and Delhi. Among village heads in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, reserved-seat winners are 7 to 15 percentage points less likely to hold a university degree. Among Kerala's village council members and in the two cities, the estimated graduate-share differences are smaller and their confidence intervals include zero. Economic position differs in every village, block and city office with occupation records: reserved-seat winners are 22 to 55 points more likely to report no occupation, and they declare lower assets in Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh. In Mumbai and Delhi they are 11 to 27 points less likely to face a pending criminal case. Across five distinct samples in the existing literature, reserved-seat village heads have 0.88 standard deviations less schooling.

## 1 Introduction

Gender quotas broaden access to elected office. Whether they also change officeholders' qualifications matters for how representative government works. Local officials must interpret administrative rules, oversee expenditure, and negotiate with other officials (Auerbach et al. 2025). Schooling and political experience may help them perform these tasks; economic resources may affect their independence. Yet these attributes need not move together, and none alone establishes how well an official governs. The question is which qualifications change when office is reserved for women.

Research on Indian village heads often finds that winners of women-reserved seats have less schooling and prior political experience than winners of open seats (Chattopadhyay and Duflo 2001; Ban and Rao 2007; Afridi et al. 2013). That evidence has an important qualification. Women who enter politics can be positively selected relative to other women even when they have less schooling than male politicians. Evidence from Karnataka, for example, finds stronger selection on cognitive skills among female than male candidates relative to voters of their own gender (Mori et al. 2025). The qualifications of elected officials depend both on the eligible population and on who enters and wins elections.

This leaves a puzzle. Is the schooling gap a common consequence of reservation, or does it depend on the opportunities and barriers women face in a particular political setting? Much of the existing evidence concerns village heads. It does not establish whether the same pattern holds among other rural officials or urban councillors. Nor does a schooling difference establish a broader qualification disadvantage: economic position and criminal records could follow different patterns.

We extend this literature by comparing qualifications across rural and urban offices in several Indian states. A common university-degree threshold makes the education comparisons easier to interpret across settings. Occupation, assets, age, and criminal records allow us to ask whether the education pattern extends to other attributes. We also assemble the published qualification comparisons, distinguish their populations and designs, and summarize the schooling evidence without counting overlapping samples twice. The contribution is to establish how qualification differences vary across offices, settings, and attributes, rather than to infer a single ranking of leader quality.

Our analysis uses election records and candidate affidavits for rural councils in Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Kerala and municipal councils in Mumbai and Delhi. We compare winners of women-reserved and open seats separately by state, election, and office; open seats can also elect women. The regressions include geographic and caste-reservation effects where the records permit them, with standard errors clustered geographically. A causal interpretation requires reservation to be as good as randomly assigned within the comparison groups. We also examine how missing qualifications limit conclusions about all winners.

The education results differ across settings. Among village heads in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, reserved-seat winners are 7 to 15 percentage points less likely to hold a university degree. Rajasthan also has a negative estimate among winners with classifiable education, but extensive missingness prevents an all-winner conclusion. Kerala’s village ward members and the councillors of Mumbai and Delhi show no consistent graduate-share deficit, and their confidence intervals include zero. The urban intervals are too wide to establish equivalence. Comparing village ward members in Bihar and Kerala preserves the contrast, so it is not solely a difference between heads and members. Differences in women’s education and access to political life are possible explanations, but offices, election years, and data coverage also vary across settings. Our design cannot separate those explanations.

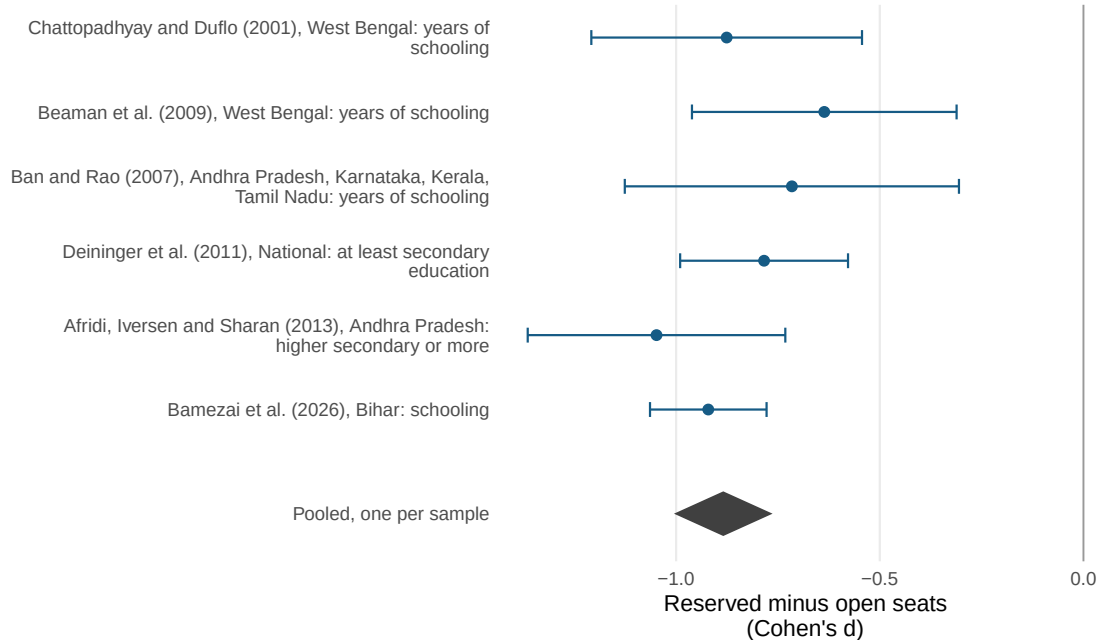
Other attributes follow different patterns. Across the village, block, and city offices with occupation records, reserved-seat winners are 22 to 55 points more likely to report no occupation, including where the estimated education differences are small. They also declare fewer assets in Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh. In Mumbai and Delhi, however, they are 11 to 27 points less likely to face a pending criminal case. The lower prevalence of charges is a potentially favorable difference, although charges are not convictions and our records do not establish its consequences for governing performance. Reservation is associated with different changes in different qualifications; the schooling evidence alone does not describe that pattern.

## 2 Related literature

### 2.1 Evidence on officials’ qualifications

The most consistent evidence on qualifications concerns schooling among village heads. Surveys generally find less schooling among winners of women-reserved seats. The comparisons assembled in Table D.1 report lower years of schooling in West Bengal and South India (Chattopadhyay and Duflo 2001, Table 3; Beaman et al. 2009, Table II; Ban and Rao 2007, Table 9), lower secondary-school attainment in a national village panel and Andhra Pradesh (Deininger et al. 2011, Table 3; Afridi et al. 2013, Table 2), and a lower standardized education score at Bihar’s reservation threshold (Bamezai et al. 2026, Table 7). These studies measure different outcomes and use different designs: most compare group means, while the Bihar study uses a reservation threshold. Their estimates should not be read as a common causal effect.

Across the five distinct samples with extractable reserved-seat versus open-seat schooling comparisons, the pooled standardized difference is -0.88 (95% CI -1.01 to -0.76). The two Birbhum studies enter once in this calculation. The summary describes this set of available estimates, rather than an exhaustive population of studies; several standard errors reconstructed from reported means and counts also omit clustering or repeated village observations. Other relevant comparisons do not enter the pool. In Tamil Nadu, female and male presidents have relatively similar reported schooling distributions (Gajwani and Zhang 2015, 246). In Maharashtra, female sarpanches have fewer years of schooling, but the study compares women and men, including a woman elected without a current reservation, rather than reserved and open seats (Priebe 2017, Table 2 and note 6).



**Figure 1:** Published comparisons of schooling among elected village heads, women-reserved minus open seats, as standardized differences with 95% confidence intervals. Years of schooling are divided by the pooled within-group standard deviation; shares of heads with secondary schooling are converted through the log odds ratio; Bamezai et al. report standard-deviation units. The pooled estimate is a random-effects mean over five independent samples, with the Birbhum councils entered once through Chattopadhyay and Duflo.

Schooling is one component of preparation for office. Reserved-seat leaders also have less prior political experience in West Bengal, South India, and Andhra Pradesh (Chattopadhyay and Duflo 2001, Table 3; Ban and Rao 2007, Table 9; Afridi et al. 2013, Table 2). Local officials must also understand administrative procedures, obtain information, and negotiate with other officials. Village heads' responsibilities for budgets, public works, and benefit allocation make these skills relevant (Auerbach et al. 2025, 708–10; Joshi et al. 2025, 56). In Tamil Nadu, female presidents score 3.2 points lower on a 19-question test of panchayat rules and duties after adjustment for schooling and other observed characteristics. They also report less contact with higher-level officials (Gajwani and Zhang 2015, Tables 5–6). The knowledge coefficient is an adjusted gender comparison, not an estimate of the causal contribution of schooling. It nevertheless shows why similar educational attainment need not imply similar preparation for governing.

## 2.2 Possible mechanisms

Lower schooling relative to open-seat winners can coexist with positive selection relative to other women. Reserved-seat leaders in Bihar are more educated than the average woman in their villages (Bamezai et al. 2026, sec. 7.2.2). Their husbands, however, have 0.36 standard deviations less schooling than open-seat winners (Bamezai et al. 2026, Table 7). In South India, they are wealthier and more politically informed than eligible women (Ban and Rao 2007, Table 9). Evidence from Karnataka similarly finds that female candidates are more positively selected on cognitive skills relative to female voters than male candidates are relative to male voters, while quotas allow households with less leadership experience to enter electoral politics (Mori et al. 2025). These comparisons distinguish two potential sources of qualification gaps: differences between the eligible populations and differences in whom elections draw from each population. Our winner records cannot separate them.

Gender quotas can also change representation along dimensions other than gender. In the Rural Economic and Demographic Survey, reservation for women reduces high-caste candidacy and representation; differences in women’s mobility across caste groups provide a possible explanation (Cassan and Vandewalle 2021, Tables 1–2 and 9–11). Education, assets, caste, and family political experience may therefore change together. Our controls for a seat’s caste-reservation category distinguish institutional categories, but do not isolate the mechanisms through which candidates enter or voters choose among them.

Experience can alter these differences after entry into office. In Andhra Pradesh, councils reserved for women initially show more leakage and implementation problems in a public employment program, but audit outcomes improve as female leaders accumulate experience (Afridi et al. 2013). Evidence from South India also links political experience to women’s performance in office (Ban and Rao 2007). Among citizens in Uttar Pradesh, gaps in political participation persist after accounting for education, political knowledge, assets, and restrictions on mobility, suggesting that observed qualifications do not exhaust the barriers to participation (Iyer and Mani 2019). Entry qualifications and the opportunities to acquire governing experience are distinct objects of study.

Formal office also differs from authority over decisions. Research on rural councils documents limits on women’s participation in deliberation and the involvement of male relatives in everyday governance (Heinze et al. 2025; Amar et al. 2025; Karekurve-Ramachandra and Sood 2026). Publicly reported work on collective family governance finds family involvement in both male- and female-led councils, alongside lower political authority for women (Huidobro et al., n.d.). These findings caution against interpreting every family connection as evidence of substitution for the elected official. Our occupation and asset measures describe economic position; they do not directly measure control over household resources or the exercise of political authority. A declaration of no occupation may also encompass substantial unpaid work.

## 2.3 Qualifications and governing performance

The association between formal qualifications and performance is itself an empirical question. More educated council heads in South India allocate benefits differently, including greater targeting to landless households (Besley et al. 2007, Tables 4–5). Graduates who narrowly win Indian state assembly elections increase constituency night-time-light growth (Jain et al. 2022, Table 2). Evidence from national leaders, US legislators, and Brazilian mayors, however, does not establish a general performance advantage for college graduates (Carnes and Lupu 2016). Other attributes have their own implications: narrowly electing legislators who face criminal charges reduces growth

and road provision in India (Prakash et al. 2019), while younger Italian mayors facing reelection exhibit larger electoral budget cycles (Alesina et al. 2019, Tables 5–7). None of these findings warrants combining schooling, age, wealth, and criminal records into a single ranking of leader quality.

The effects of reservation on governance extend beyond the credentials of the elected official. In West Bengal and Rajasthan, reservation changes public investment toward goods requested by women (Chattopadhyay and Duflo 2004, Table V). Within India, the evidence varies by outcome and setting. Tamil Nadu’s female-led councils build fewer schools and roads (Gajwani and Zhang 2015, Tables 7–8), while a broader village survey finds greater public-goods availability and fewer reported bribes despite lower satisfaction with female leaders (Duflo and Topalova 2004, Tables 2–4). In Maharashtra, improvements in women’s political participation coexist with mixed service-delivery differences (Priebe 2017, Tables 4 and 6). Repeated exposure to female leaders in West Bengal also raises girls’ aspirations and educational attainment (Beaman et al. 2012, Tables 1–3). These outcomes concern policy, participation, and longer-run opportunities, which our records of officeholders do not measure.

The unresolved question for this paper is how broadly the qualification differences documented among village heads extend across offices and attributes. We address that question with comparable measures where the administrative records permit them, while retaining separate estimates for each setting.

### 3 Institutional setting, data, and empirical strategy

#### 3.1 Reserved seats and the comparison

Women-reserved seats restrict eligibility to women; open seats permit both women and men to contest. Gender reservation also operates within caste-reservation categories. These rules change eligibility, but their assignment procedures differ across jurisdictions. We therefore retain separate state, election, and office comparisons and make the identifying assumption explicit below. Differences across settings also reflect differences in offices, election years, and source coverage; they do not by themselves identify an effect of a state’s social or institutional environment.

#### 3.2 Data sources

The administrative records come from state election repositories through `local_elections`, with input hashes, winner rules, exclusions and coding dictionaries saved in the repository. Bihar’s winner is the highest vote-getter, an uncontested candidate, or the winner of a tie drawn by lot; seats whose results form cannot identify a winner are excluded. Kerala’s records are of elected ward members, and their reservation refers to the ward even for members who later lead the council.

Bihar’s 2021 records include age but not education. We obtain reservation status from the State Election Commission’s feed for the 2021–2026 term and verify that it reproduces the Commission’s count of women-reserved village-head seats. Kerala records education as free text; we classify recognized degrees and school qualifications and leave incomplete or unrecognized entries missing.

Mumbai’s councillor records come from the Praja Foundation’s report cards and affidavits, as deposited by Karekurve-Ramachandra and Lee (2023). Each councillor with a recorded age enters once per term.

The Delhi data cover the municipal elections of 2012, 2017, and 2022. Winners and assembly mapping for 2012 and 2017 come from Goyal’s replication deposit (Goyal 2023); for 2022, winners come from the OpenCity compilation of Lok Dhaba results and reservation from the State Election Commission’s gazette (Vaidyanathan 2023; State Election Commission, NCT of Delhi 2022, Annexure B). The 2012 reservation labels match the official schedule (State Election Commission, NCT of Delhi 2012, Annexures I–III). Qualifications and pending cases come from each winner’s MyNeta profile (Association for Democratic Reforms 2026); convictions are excluded from pending cases. We use these profiles to measure Delhi winners’ education because the older deposited classifications disagree with the affidavits. The measurement appendix reports that comparison.

### 3.3 Outcomes and samples

The main education outcome is whether the winner holds a university degree; the appendix also reports illiteracy. Unknown qualifications stay missing. Occupation is recorded in Rajasthan, Kerala and Delhi. A winner counts as having no occupation when the entry is nil, unemployed, homemaker or student; pensioners and every named trade or job count as an occupation, with the coding rules recorded in the accompanying analysis code.

Declared assets come from the nomination affidavits of Rajasthan’s 2020 and Uttar Pradesh’s 2021 village heads. We analyze declared assets on a logarithmic scale.

MyNeta’s affidavit summaries record pending criminal cases in Mumbai and Delhi. Uttar Pradesh’s 2021 affidavits instead provide an indicator of reported criminal history.

### 3.4 Specification and inference

For each state, election and office, we estimate

$$Y_i = \alpha + \beta R_i + \gamma_{g(i)} + \delta_{c(i)} + \epsilon_i,$$

where  $R_i$  indicates a seat reserved for women,  $\gamma_{g(i)}$  is a block effect (a district effect where blocks are not recorded throughout) and  $\delta_{c(i)}$  is an effect for the seat’s caste-reservation class. For binary outcomes,  $100\beta$  is the reserved-minus-open difference in percentage points among seats in the same block and caste class. It is the effect of reservation if reservation is as good as randomly assigned within those cells. Standard errors are clustered by block or district, and 95% intervals use a  $t$  distribution with one fewer degree of freedom than there are clusters; Kerala’s ward and district-member models have only 14 clusters. Mumbai pools its 2012 and 2017 councils with administrative-ward and council effects, clustered by electoral ward, and has no caste-reservation control. Delhi uses assembly-constituency and caste-reservation effects in each election, clustered by assembly constituency.

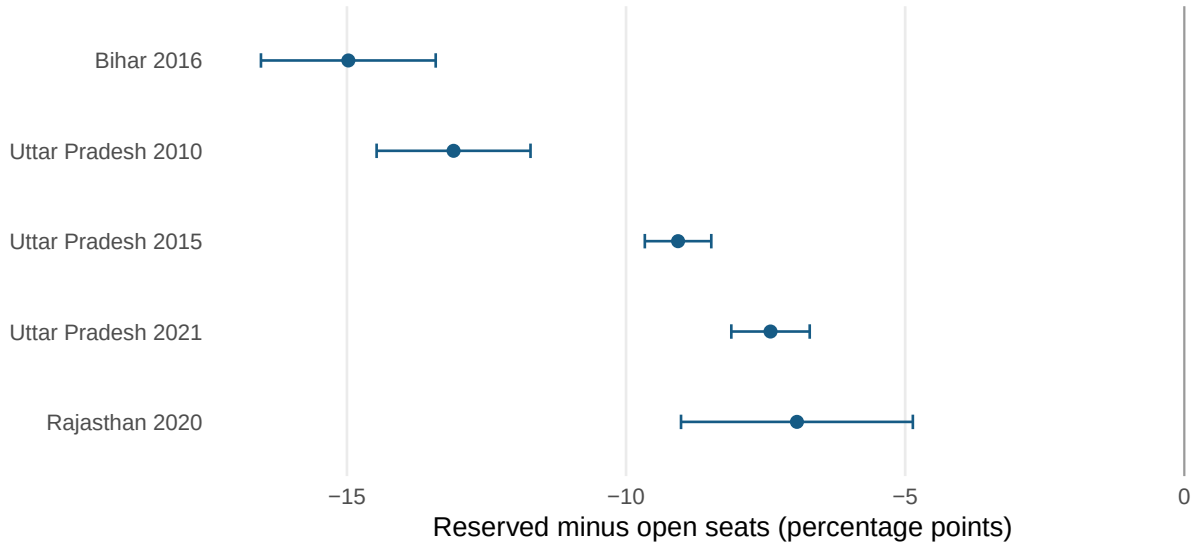
## 4 Results

### 4.1 Rural panchayats

#### 4.1.1 Village heads

Among village heads in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, winners of women-reserved seats are less likely to hold a university degree. In Bihar’s 2016 election, the adjusted graduate-share difference is -15.0 percentage points (95% CI -16.5 to -13.4). Uttar Pradesh shows the same direction in each election. Its estimated differences are -13.1 percentage points (95% CI -14.5 to -11.7) in 2010, -9.1 percentage points (95% CI -9.7 to -8.5) in 2015, and -7.4 percentage points (95% CI -8.1 to -6.7) in 2021. The estimated deficit narrows over time, but all three intervals remain below zero. These are comparisons of the winners in each election, not changes in the qualifications of the same individuals.

#### Rural village heads: graduate or above



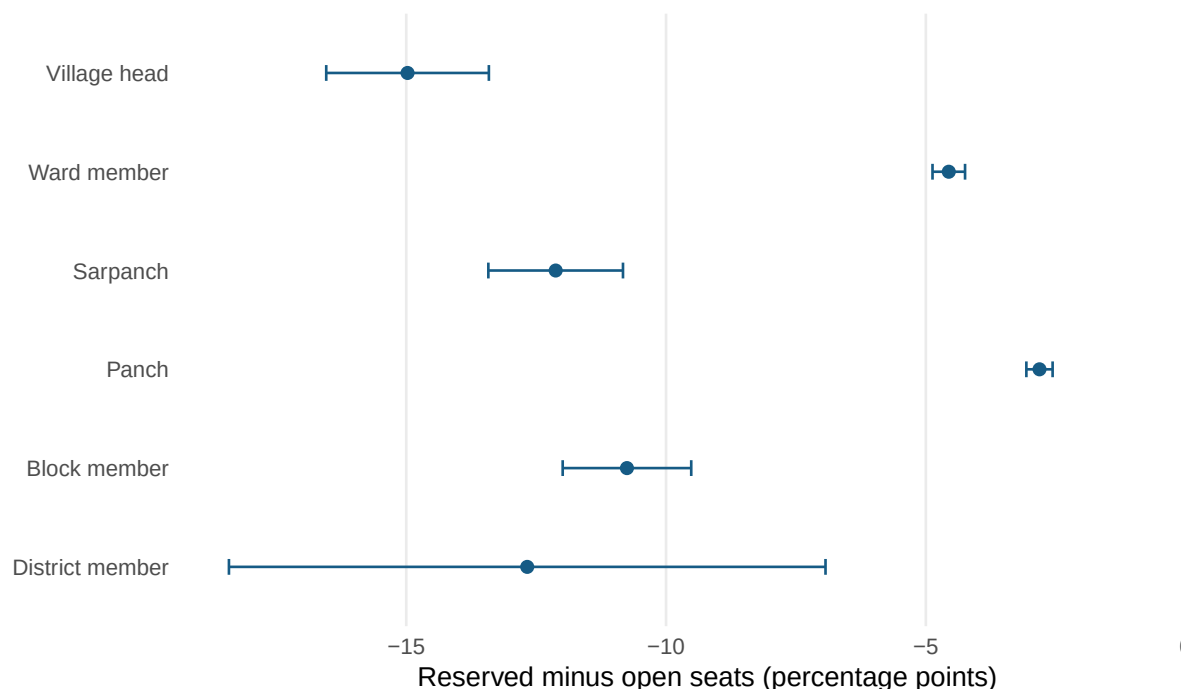
**Figure 2:** Graduate-share differences among rural village heads, women-reserved minus open seats, with geography and caste-reservation effects. Bars are 95% confidence intervals clustered by geography. UP 2010 uses districts; other rows use blocks. Unclassified education, ambiguous winners and unknown reservation are excluded.

Rajasthan also has a negative education difference among village heads whose qualifications can be classified: -6.9 percentage points (95% CI -9.0 to -4.9). Here, however, missing education changes the conclusion we can draw. Many records report only “Other,” and the share with classifiable education differs between reserved and open seats. Allowing each unclassified winner to be either a graduate or a nongraduate yields an all-winner coefficient between -29.7 and 31.5 percentage points. This range allows substantial differences in either direction. The observed negative gap therefore describes the classified sample; it does not establish a graduate-share deficit among all Rajasthan village heads. These bounds address missing outcomes and do not incorporate sampling uncertainty.

### 4.1.2 Bihar's other offices

The education difference in Bihar extends beyond village heads. The 2016 records cover 210,717 elected seats across six village, block, and district offices. Reserved-seat winners have lower graduate shares in every office, although the size of the difference varies. Among village ward members, the adjusted difference is -4.6 percentage points (95% CI -4.9 to -4.2); among block council members it is -10.8 percentage points (95% CI -12.0 to -9.5). The gap is thus present among council members as well as heads, rather than being confined to the village executive office.

#### Bihar 2016: graduate or above



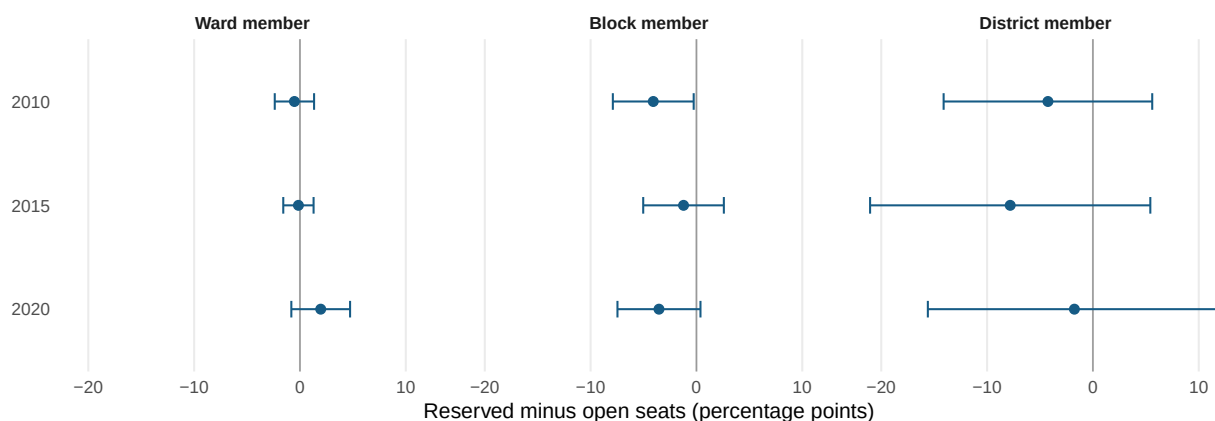
**Figure 3:** Bihar 2016: graduate-share differences by office, women-reserved minus open seats, with block and caste-reservation effects (district effects for district council members). Bars are 95% confidence intervals clustered at that level.

Reserved-seat village heads are also younger. The estimated age difference is 3.6 years in 2016 and 3.2 years in 2021 (95% CI 2.7 to 3.6). The 2021 data cover 244,474 elected seats but contain no education measure, so they cannot establish whether the schooling gap persisted. Age describes another difference in who holds office; without records of prior political experience, it cannot establish that younger winners are less prepared to govern.

### 4.1.3 Kerala

Kerala's village ward members show much smaller education differences. The adjusted graduate-share differences are -0.5 percentage points (95% CI -2.4 to 1.3) in 2010, -0.1 percentage points (95% CI -1.6 to 1.3) in 2015, and 2.0 percentage points (95% CI -0.8 to 4.7) in 2020. Each interval includes zero, and none includes a deficit as large as the one estimated for Bihar's village ward members. Comparing this common office therefore preserves the contrast between Bihar and Kerala; the pattern is not simply a consequence of comparing northern heads with Kerala's council members.

## Kerala: graduate or above



**Figure 4:** Rural Kerala: graduate-share differences by election and office, women-reserved minus open seats, with caste-reservation effects. Block members use block effects and clustering; village and district members use districts. Bars are 95% confidence intervals.

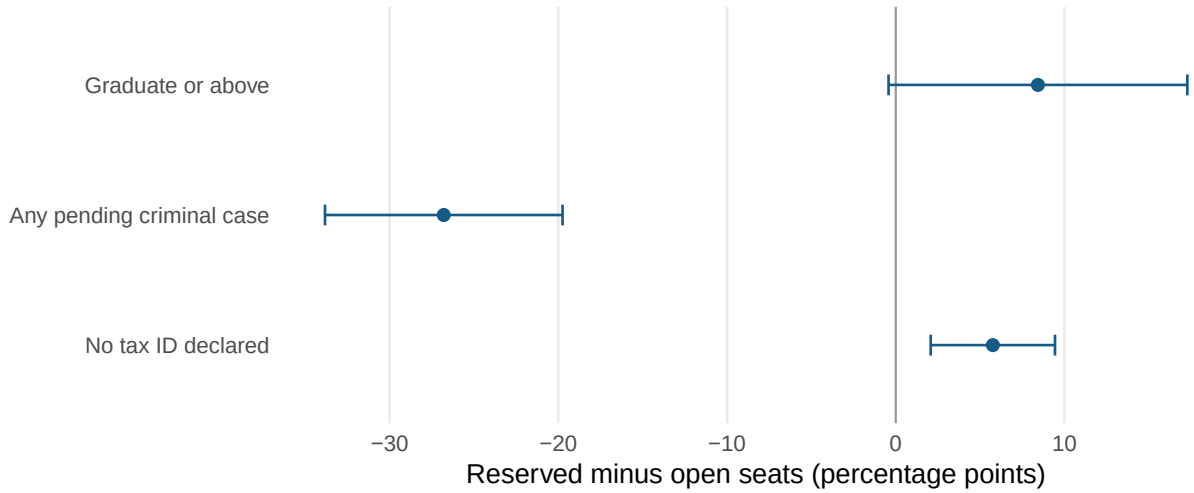
This result applies most clearly to village ward members, not to every Kerala office. For block council members, the estimated differences are negative in all three elections, and the 2010 interval excludes zero (-4.1 percentage points (95% CI -7.9 to -0.3)). The district council estimates are also negative but substantially less precise. Moreover, these comparisons describe winners with classifiable education. The missing-outcome bounds for Kerala permit either sign, so small estimated gaps in the observed sample do not establish equal educational attainment among all elected officials.

## 4.2 Urban councils

### 4.2.1 Mumbai

Mumbai does not show the graduate-share deficit found among northern village heads. Across the 2012 and 2017 councils, the adjusted difference is 8.4 percentage points (95% CI -0.4 to 17.3). The point estimate favors reserved-seat winners, but its interval includes zero. Within the observed sample and regression specification, the interval permits a negligible disadvantage or a substantial advantage; it provides little support for a deficit of the magnitude observed among northern village heads.

### Urban: Mumbai councillors, 2012 and 2017



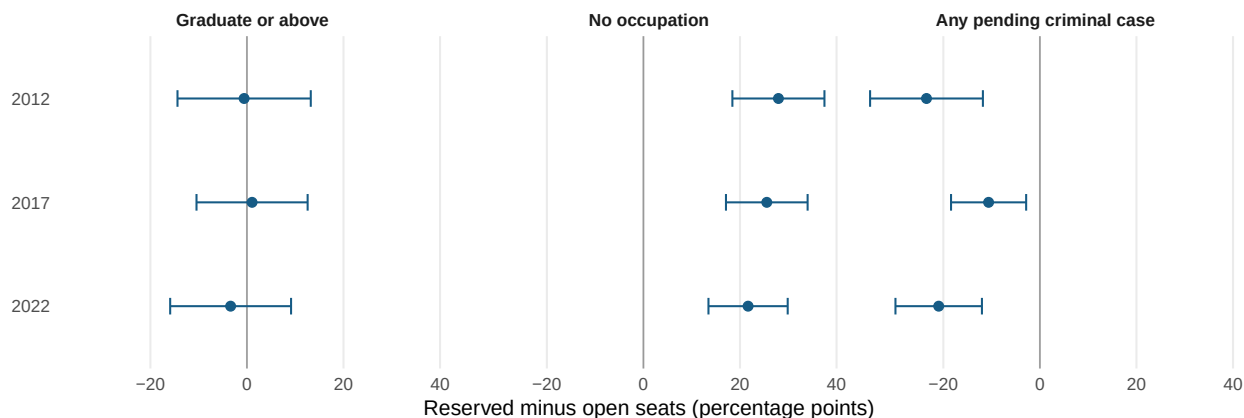
**Figure 5:** Mumbai councillors in the 2012 and 2017 councils: women-reserved minus open seats in graduate share, any pending case and declaring no tax ID (PAN), with administrative-ward and council effects. Bars are 95% confidence intervals clustered by electoral ward.

The difference in pending criminal cases is larger and more precisely estimated. Reserved-seat councillors are 26.8 percentage points less likely to face a pending case (95% CI 19.7 to 33.8). This is a difference in the prevalence of charges against elected officials. It does not measure convictions or establish how reservation affects misconduct or performance in office.

#### 4.2.2 Delhi

In Delhi, the estimated graduate-share differences are small, but their uncertainty is substantial. The estimated graduate-share differences are -0.6 percentage points (95% CI -14.4 to 13.2) in 2012, 1.1 percentage points (95% CI -10.4 to 12.6) in 2017, and -3.4 percentage points (95% CI -15.9 to 9.1) in 2022. The estimates vary in sign, and all three intervals include sizable differences in both directions. The Delhi results therefore do not establish an education advantage or disadvantage, and they are too imprecise to establish equivalent graduate shares.

#### Urban: Delhi councillors



**Figure 6:** Delhi councillors by election: women-reserved minus open seats in graduate share, reporting no occupation and any pending case, with assembly-constituency and caste-reservation effects. Bars are 95% confidence intervals clustered by assembly constituency.

Pending criminal cases show a more consistent pattern. The reserved-minus-open differences are -23.5 percentage points (95% CI -35.2 to -11.8) in 2012, -10.6 percentage points (95% CI -18.4 to -2.8) in 2017, and -21.0 percentage points (95% CI -29.9 to -12.0) in 2022. All three intervals lie below zero. The sign also remains negative when every missing case indicator is allowed to be either zero or one, holding the regression design fixed. These bounds address incomplete records and do not incorporate sampling uncertainty. They also cannot establish the accuracy of declarations or the consequences of pending cases for governance. The urban evidence is consequently clearer about the lower prevalence of charges than about differences in educational attainment.

### 4.3 Occupation, assets and criminal records

Differences in reported occupation extend to settings where the education estimates are close to zero. In Rajasthan, the share reporting no occupation is 51 percentage points higher among reserved-seat village heads (95% CI 48 to 54). Among Kerala’s village ward members, the estimated differences range from 41 to 55 points across the three elections; among Delhi’s councillors, they range from 22 to 28 points. Thus, the small education differences in these settings coexist with large differences in reported occupation. Kerala’s district council members show smaller occupation differences, ranging from 0 to 15 points.

The occupation measure combines declarations of no work, unemployment, homemaking, and student status. It describes reported occupation, not the absence of productive activity or access to household resources. Coding “social worker” as missing rather than as an occupation changes no estimate by more than 6 percentage points, so that particular coding choice does not account for the broad pattern. The records do not show whether women with no reported occupation control assets or exercise political authority independently.

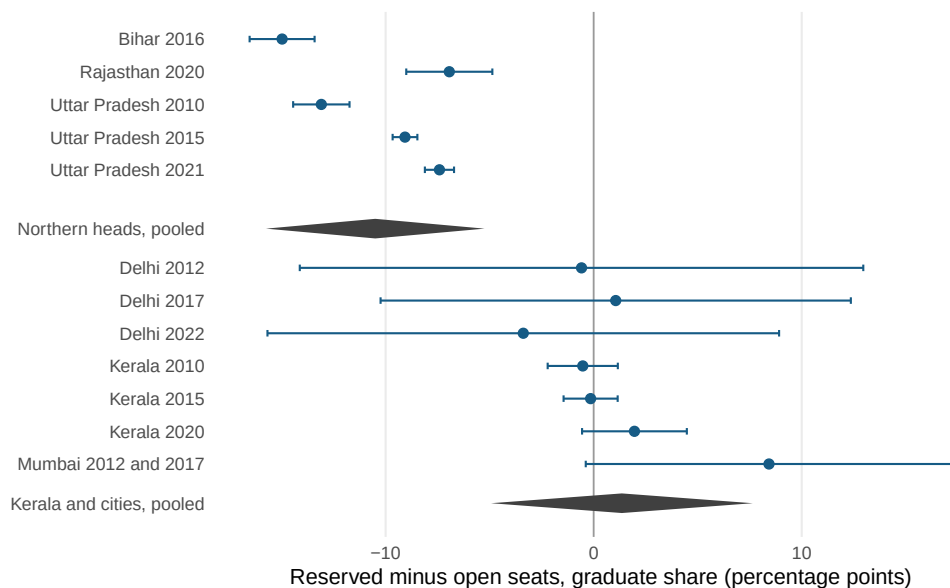
Mumbai’s records contain no occupation measure. The adjusted difference in the share declaring no tax identification number (PAN) is 5.8 percentage points (95% CI 2.1 to 9.4), with nondeclaration more common among reserved-seat winners. Nondeclaration occurs only in the 2012 council records. This is an additional difference in affidavit disclosure; it cannot substitute for a direct measure of employment or income.

Reserved-seat village heads declare fewer assets in both states with asset records. The estimates imply approximately 47% lower assets in Rajasthan (95% CI 40% to 54% lower) and 9% lower assets in Uttar Pradesh (95% CI 5% to 13% lower). The asset differences reinforce the evidence from occupation that reserved-seat winners occupy a different economic position. Affidavits record declared holdings, however, and do not establish who controls those resources.

The urban difference in pending cases does not have a clear counterpart in Uttar Pradesh’s village-head records. Only 0.18% of winners with a known record report a criminal history. The adjusted reserved-minus-open difference is -0.04 percentage points (95% CI -0.12 to 0.04), leaving the direction uncertain. This outcome is reported criminal history, whereas the urban measure concerns pending cases, so differences across these settings also reflect the measures available. The appendix reports the full estimates and sample sizes.

## 5 Discussion

The graduate-share deficit is larger among northern village heads than among Kerala’s village ward members and the two cities’ councillors. Pooling this paper’s estimates with elections nested in settings, reserved-seat village heads in the northern states are 10.5 points less likely to hold a degree (95% CI 5.2 to 15.8), against a difference of 1.4 points (-4.9 to 7.6) among Kerala’s ward members and the two cities’ councillors. Distinguishing the two groups reduces the estimated standard deviation of residual differences across settings from 7.3 to 2.6 points. Office, data source and election years vary along with setting, and the second group is one state and two cities. Replacing Bihar’s village heads with its ward members, the office we observe in Kerala, still leaves a northern gap of 7.5 points.



**Figure 7:** This paper’s graduate-share differences, women-reserved minus open seats, with 95% confidence intervals. Pooled estimates come from a random-effects model with elections nested in settings and an indicator for the northern village-head settings.

Where the education estimates are close to zero, the differences in reported occupation remain large. This pattern is consistent with unequal economic opportunities, but occupation records alone cannot establish who controls resources or exercises the office. In a Rajasthan phone audit, 9% of answered calls to reserved-seat village heads reached the elected woman, against 76% in open seats and 31.7% in urban Jaipur (Karekurve-Ramachandra and Sood 2026, 1–2). Women elected through quotas participate less in council decisions (Heinze et al. 2025), and surveys in two states find male family members prominent in everyday governance (Amar et al. 2025). For the same reason, the lower rate of pending cases among urban reserved-seat councillors may overstate the change in the office’s criminal exposure: affidavits list the officeholder’s own cases, not her relatives’, and Karekurve-Ramachandra and Lee (2020a, 11) note that many Mumbai quota women have male relatives who face charges.

Assessing how qualification differences affect governing performance requires direct measures of officials’ behavior. Separate evidence from Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh finds no detectable effect of lottery-assigned reservation on the scale or content of public works (Green et al. 2026). Our administrative records establish differences in who holds office; they cannot establish the consequences of those differences.

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## A Measurement and reproducibility

### A.1 Affidavit verification

We do not use the education recorded in the older Delhi files, whose coding also appears in Karekurve-Ramachandra and Lee’s deposit (Sood 2022; Karekurve-Ramachandra and Lee 2020b). For the 2012 winners, the deposited graduate classification agrees with the winners’ own MyNeta profiles 54% of the time, close to the agreement obtained after randomly shuffling the deposited values across winners (53%), while the same records’ declared assets match 97% of the time. The 2017 education labels agree with the profiles for 261 of 262 winners. In the Mumbai audit sample, the deposited education and pending-case indicators agree with MyNeta.

### A.2 Asset measurement

The asset regressions use  $\log(A + 1)$ , where  $A$  is declared assets in rupees. The added rupee retains zero declarations. Percentage differences are  $100[\exp(\hat{\beta}) - 1]$ , with the same transformation applied to the confidence limits.

### A.3 Coverage and missing outcomes

**Table A.1:** Education coverage among eligible winner records. N includes unclassified qualifications.

| State     | Year | Office          | Seat  | Classified (%) | N      |
|-----------|------|-----------------|-------|----------------|--------|
| UP        | 2010 | Village head    | Open  | 99.6           | 34,654 |
| UP        | 2010 | Village head    | Women | 99.4           | 17,166 |
| UP        | 2015 | Village head    | Open  | 100.0          | 39,093 |
| UP        | 2015 | Village head    | Women | 100.0          | 19,926 |
| UP        | 2021 | Village head    | Open  | 95.3           | 32,997 |
| UP        | 2021 | Village head    | Women | 94.1           | 16,774 |
| Rajasthan | 2020 | Village head    | Open  | 81.8           | 5,695  |
| Rajasthan | 2020 | Village head    | Women | 56.9           | 5,433  |
| Kerala    | 2010 | Block member    | Open  | 91.0           | 983    |
| Kerala    | 2010 | Block member    | Women | 93.0           | 1,095  |
| Kerala    | 2010 | Ward member     | Open  | 89.7           | 8,047  |
| Kerala    | 2010 | Ward member     | Women | 90.8           | 8,594  |
| Kerala    | 2010 | District member | Open  | 87.7           | 162    |
| Kerala    | 2010 | District member | Women | 94.7           | 169    |
| Kerala    | 2015 | Block member    | Open  | 87.4           | 1,021  |
| Kerala    | 2015 | Block member    | Women | 88.7           | 1,041  |
| Kerala    | 2015 | Ward member     | Open  | 87.6           | 7,725  |
| Kerala    | 2015 | Ward member     | Women | 89.7           | 8,196  |
| Kerala    | 2015 | District member | Open  | 86.0           | 164    |
| Kerala    | 2015 | District member | Women | 92.2           | 167    |
| Kerala    | 2020 | Block member    | Open  | 88.7           | 980    |
| Kerala    | 2020 | Block member    | Women | 89.3           | 1,098  |
| Kerala    | 2020 | Ward member     | Open  | 83.8           | 7,726  |
| Kerala    | 2020 | Ward member     | Women | 84.9           | 8,226  |
| Kerala    | 2020 | District member | Open  | 86.1           | 166    |

| State  | Year | Office          | Seat  | Classified (%) | N   |
|--------|------|-----------------|-------|----------------|-----|
| Kerala | 2020 | District member | Women | 84.2           | 165 |

Education is missing for many winners in Rajasthan, where qualifications are often recorded as “Other”, and is classified at different rates across Kerala’s seat types. Ages outside 21 to 100 are set to missing. Some Uttar Pradesh inputs come from integration work not yet in a published release of the election data; the repository keeps their byte hashes and the adapter diff.

The missing-education bounds keep the all-winner regression design and let each unclassified winner be either a graduate or not. After reservation is residualized on the controls, the coefficient is a weighted sum of outcomes, so assigning each missing outcome by the sign of its weight gives the exact minimum and maximum. The bounds carry no sampling uncertainty. Uttar Pradesh’s bounds are negative in each election; Rajasthan’s and Kerala’s include both signs.

**Table A.2:** Missing-education bounds on the adjusted all-winner graduate-share difference (percentage points). These are not confidence intervals.

| State     | Year | Office          | Lower | Upper | Missing | N      |
|-----------|------|-----------------|-------|-------|---------|--------|
| UP        | 2010 | Village head    | -13.5 | -12.4 | 254     | 51,820 |
| UP        | 2015 | Village head    | -9.1  | -9.1  | 0       | 59,019 |
| UP        | 2021 | Village head    | -12.0 | -1.3  | 2,543   | 49,771 |
| Rajasthan | 2020 | Village head    | -29.7 | 31.5  | 3,380   | 11,128 |
| Kerala    | 2010 | Block member    | -12.3 | 3.4   | 165     | 2,078  |
| Kerala    | 2010 | Ward member     | -10.6 | 8.9   | 1,617   | 16,641 |
| Kerala    | 2010 | District member | -12.7 | 4.8   | 29      | 331    |
| Kerala    | 2015 | Block member    | -13.8 | 10.1  | 247     | 2,062  |
| Kerala    | 2015 | Ward member     | -12.2 | 10.5  | 1,800   | 15,921 |
| Kerala    | 2015 | District member | -18.0 | 3.7   | 36      | 331    |
| Kerala    | 2020 | Block member    | -14.5 | 7.5   | 228     | 2,078  |
| Kerala    | 2020 | Ward member     | -14.4 | 16.9  | 2,495   | 15,952 |
| Kerala    | 2020 | District member | -15.1 | 15.2  | 49      | 331    |

## B Complete rural estimates

### B.1 Bihar: education

**Table B.1:** Bihar rural officials: two parts of the education distribution. Differences in percentage points with pointwise 95% confidence intervals. N: classified winners; G: geographic clusters. Caste controls included.

| Year | Office       | Graduate or above    | Illiterate        | N      | G   | Controls |
|------|--------------|----------------------|-------------------|--------|-----|----------|
| 2016 | Village head | -15.0 [-16.5, -13.4] | 1.5 [0.9, 2.1]    | 7,873  | 523 | Block    |
| 2016 | Ward member  | -4.6 [-4.9, -4.2]    | 11.5 [10.8, 12.3] | 97,200 | 517 | Block    |
| 2016 | Sarpanch     | -12.1 [-13.4, -10.8] | 4.7 [3.7, 5.6]    | 7,841  | 521 | Block    |
| 2016 | Panch        | -2.8 [-3.1, -2.6]    | 14.8 [14.0, 15.7] | 85,355 | 516 | Block    |
| 2016 | Block member | -10.8 [-12.0, -9.5]  | 3.2 [2.5, 4.0]    | 10,743 | 519 | Block    |

| Year | Office          | Graduate or above   | Illiterate      | N   | G  | Controls |
|------|-----------------|---------------------|-----------------|-----|----|----------|
| 2016 | District member | -12.7 [-18.4, -6.9] | 1.3 [-0.4, 2.9] | 888 | 38 | District |

## B.2 Uttar Pradesh: education

**Table B.2:** Uttar Pradesh rural officials: two parts of the education distribution. Differences in percentage points with pointwise 95% confidence intervals. N: classified winners; G: geographic clusters. Caste controls included.

| Year | Office       | Graduate or above    | Illiterate      | N      | G   | Controls |
|------|--------------|----------------------|-----------------|--------|-----|----------|
| 2010 | Village head | -13.1 [-14.5, -11.7] | 6.3 [5.1, 7.4]  | 51,566 | 72  | District |
| 2015 | Village head | -9.1 [-9.7, -8.5]    | 9.3 [8.7, 10.0] | 59,019 | 823 | Block    |
| 2021 | Village head | -7.4 [-8.1, -6.7]    | 8.2 [7.5, 9.0]  | 47,228 | 728 | Block    |

## B.3 Rajasthan: education

**Table B.3:** Rajasthan rural officials: two parts of the education distribution. Differences in percentage points with pointwise 95% confidence intervals. N: classified winners; G: geographic clusters. Caste controls included.

| Year | Office       | Graduate or above | Illiterate      | N     | G   | Controls |
|------|--------------|-------------------|-----------------|-------|-----|----------|
| 2020 | Village head | -6.9 [-9.0, -4.9] | 0.1 [-0.1, 0.2] | 7,748 | 352 | Block    |

## B.4 Kerala: education

**Table B.4:** Kerala rural officials: two parts of the education distribution. Differences in percentage points with pointwise 95% confidence intervals. N: classified winners; G: geographic clusters. Caste controls included. Illiteracy is unavailable.

| Year | Office          | Graduate or above  | Illiterate | N      | G   | Controls |
|------|-----------------|--------------------|------------|--------|-----|----------|
| 2010 | Ward member     | -0.5 [-2.4, 1.3]   | —          | 15,024 | 14  | District |
| 2010 | Block member    | -4.1 [-7.9, -0.3]  | —          | 1,913  | 150 | Block    |
| 2010 | District member | -4.3 [-14.1, 5.6]  | —          | 302    | 14  | District |
| 2015 | Ward member     | -0.1 [-1.6, 1.3]   | —          | 14,121 | 14  | District |
| 2015 | Block member    | -1.2 [-5.0, 2.6]   | —          | 1,815  | 148 | Block    |
| 2015 | District member | -7.8 [-21.1, 5.4]  | —          | 295    | 14  | District |
| 2020 | Ward member     | 2.0 [-0.8, 4.7]    | —          | 13,457 | 14  | District |
| 2020 | Block member    | -3.5 [-7.5, 0.4]   | —          | 1,850  | 149 | Block    |
| 2020 | District member | -1.8 [-15.6, 12.1] | —          | 282    | 14  | District |

## B.5 Age

**Table B.5:** Age of rural officials: differences in years with pointwise 95% confidence intervals. N: winners with age recorded; G: geographic clusters. Controls match the education models.

| State         | Year | Office          | Difference [95% CI] | N       | G   |
|---------------|------|-----------------|---------------------|---------|-----|
| Bihar         | 2016 | Village head    | -3.6 [-4.1, -3.2]   | 7,934   | 524 |
| Bihar         | 2016 | Ward member     | -2.0 [-2.2, -1.8]   | 97,211  | 517 |
| Bihar         | 2016 | Sarpanch        | -5.6 [-6.2, -5.1]   | 7,871   | 521 |
| Bihar         | 2016 | Panch           | -2.9 [-3.1, -2.7]   | 85,376  | 516 |
| Bihar         | 2016 | Block member    | -2.7 [-3.1, -2.3]   | 10,775  | 519 |
| Bihar         | 2016 | District member | -4.2 [-5.6, -2.7]   | 891     | 38  |
| Bihar         | 2021 | Village head    | -3.2 [-3.6, -2.7]   | 8,050   | 533 |
| Bihar         | 2021 | Ward member     | -0.5 [-0.6, -0.3]   | 109,501 | 533 |
| Bihar         | 2021 | Sarpanch        | -6.2 [-6.7, -5.7]   | 8,043   | 533 |
| Bihar         | 2021 | Panch           | -3.2 [-3.4, -3.0]   | 106,636 | 533 |
| Bihar         | 2021 | Block member    | -2.3 [-2.7, -1.9]   | 10,972  | 533 |
| Bihar         | 2021 | District member | -3.9 [-5.0, -2.8]   | 1,144   | 38  |
| Uttar Pradesh | 2010 | Village head    | -1.4 [-1.6, -1.2]   | 51,662  | 72  |
| Uttar Pradesh | 2021 | Village head    | -1.3 [-1.5, -1.1]   | 49,757  | 728 |
| Rajasthan     | 2020 | Village head    | -1.7 [-2.3, -1.1]   | 11,113  | 352 |
| Kerala        | 2010 | Ward member     | -4.8 [-5.9, -3.8]   | 14,793  | 14  |
| Kerala        | 2010 | Block member    | -4.9 [-5.8, -4.0]   | 1,980   | 151 |
| Kerala        | 2010 | District member | -4.2 [-7.3, -1.2]   | 330     | 14  |
| Kerala        | 2015 | Ward member     | -4.2 [-5.2, -3.2]   | 15,724  | 14  |
| Kerala        | 2015 | Block member    | -3.9 [-4.9, -3.0]   | 2,029   | 151 |
| Kerala        | 2015 | District member | -3.0 [-5.8, -0.3]   | 327     | 14  |
| Kerala        | 2020 | Ward member     | -3.5 [-4.5, -2.4]   | 15,860  | 14  |
| Kerala        | 2020 | Block member    | -3.1 [-4.0, -2.2]   | 2,070   | 152 |
| Kerala        | 2020 | District member | -3.6 [-6.0, -1.2]   | 331     | 14  |

## B.6 Occupation, assets and criminal records

**Table B.6:** Occupation, assets and criminal records: reserved minus open seats, with the controls and clustering of the education models. No occupation and criminal record in percentage points; log declared assets in log points. No occupation counts nil, unemployed, homemaker and student entries. Mumbai, which records no occupation, reports whether the councillor declared a tax ID (PAN).

| Outcome             | State         | Year       | Office          | Difference [95% CI]  | N      |
|---------------------|---------------|------------|-----------------|----------------------|--------|
| No occupation       | Delhi         | 2012       | Councillor      | 28.0 [18.4, 37.5]    | 231    |
| No occupation       | Delhi         | 2017       | Councillor      | 25.6 [17.1, 34.0]    | 264    |
| No occupation       | Delhi         | 2022       | Councillor      | 21.7 [13.5, 29.9]    | 246    |
| No occupation       | Kerala        | 2010       | Block member    | 38.8 [33.6, 43.9]    | 1,690  |
| No occupation       | Kerala        | 2010       | Ward member     | 54.5 [50.2, 58.8]    | 13,992 |
| No occupation       | Kerala        | 2010       | District member | 12.4 [0.9, 23.8]     | 241    |
| No occupation       | Kerala        | 2015       | Block member    | 35.3 [30.4, 40.3]    | 1,654  |
| No occupation       | Kerala        | 2015       | Ward member     | 50.2 [44.9, 55.4]    | 12,647 |
| No occupation       | Kerala        | 2015       | District member | 15.1 [6.7, 23.6]     | 240    |
| No occupation       | Kerala        | 2020       | Block member    | 30.7 [25.5, 35.9]    | 1,637  |
| No occupation       | Kerala        | 2020       | Ward member     | 41.0 [35.7, 46.2]    | 12,267 |
| No occupation       | Kerala        | 2020       | District member | 0.2 [-10.3, 10.7]    | 217    |
| No occupation       | Rajasthan     | 2020       | Village head    | 51.1 [48.2, 53.9]    | 11,128 |
| No tax ID declared  | Mumbai        | 2012, 2017 | Councillor      | 5.8 [2.1, 9.4]       | 449    |
| Log declared assets | Rajasthan     | 2020       | Village head    | -0.64 [-0.77, -0.51] | 11,128 |
| Log declared assets | Uttar Pradesh | 2021       | Village head    | -0.10 [-0.14, -0.05] | 49,771 |
| Criminal record     | Uttar Pradesh | 2021       | Village head    | -0.04 [-0.12, 0.04]  | 42,720 |

## C Delhi estimates and coverage

**Table C.1:** Delhi councillors: adjusted differences in percentage points, except age in years. Assembly-constituency and caste-reservation controls; pointwise intervals clustered by assembly constituency. G denotes clusters. The occupation sensitivity excludes social workers.

| Year | Outcome                    | Difference [95% CI]  | N   | G  |
|------|----------------------------|----------------------|-----|----|
| 2012 | Graduate or above          | -0.6 [-14.4, 13.2]   | 226 | 65 |
| 2012 | Illiterate                 | 2.5 [-1.3, 6.3]      | 226 | 65 |
| 2012 | Age (years)                | -6.0 [-9.0, -3.0]    | 235 | 65 |
| 2012 | Any pending case           | -23.5 [-35.2, -11.8] | 237 | 65 |
| 2012 | No occupation              | 28.0 [18.4, 37.5]    | 231 | 64 |
| 2012 | No occupation, sensitivity | 30.9 [20.7, 41.1]    | 213 | 62 |
| 2017 | Graduate or above          | 1.1 [-10.4, 12.6]    | 262 | 68 |
| 2017 | Illiterate                 | 0.6 [-1.7, 2.8]      | 262 | 68 |
| 2017 | Age (years)                | -3.6 [-5.6, -1.5]    | 262 | 68 |
| 2017 | Any pending case           | -10.6 [-18.4, -2.8]  | 267 | 68 |
| 2017 | No occupation              | 25.6 [17.1, 34.0]    | 264 | 68 |
| 2017 | No occupation, sensitivity | 27.0 [18.1, 35.8]    | 245 | 68 |
| 2022 | Graduate or above          | -3.4 [-15.9, 9.1]    | 244 | 68 |
| 2022 | Illiterate                 | 2.4 [-1.0, 5.7]      | 244 | 68 |
| 2022 | Age (years)                | -2.3 [-4.8, 0.3]     | 248 | 68 |
| 2022 | Any pending case           | -21.0 [-29.9, -12.0] | 248 | 68 |
| 2022 | No occupation              | 21.7 [13.5, 29.9]    | 246 | 68 |
| 2022 | No occupation, sensitivity | 24.7 [15.5, 33.9]    | 226 | 68 |

**Table C.2:** Delhi outcome coverage among recorded winners. Percentages use all winners of each seat type as the denominator.

| Year | Seat  | N   | Education (%) | Age (%) | Cases (%) |
|------|-------|-----|---------------|---------|-----------|
| 2012 | Open  | 134 | 85.8          | 86.6    | 87.3      |
| 2012 | Women | 138 | 80.4          | 86.2    | 87.0      |
| 2017 | Open  | 134 | 97.0          | 98.5    | 99.3      |
| 2017 | Women | 138 | 95.7          | 94.2    | 97.1      |
| 2022 | Open  | 125 | 97.6          | 100.0   | 100.0     |
| 2022 | Women | 125 | 97.6          | 98.4    | 98.4      |

**Table C.3:** Delhi missing-outcome bounds on the adjusted all-winner coefficient, in percentage points. They carry no sampling uncertainty.

| Year | Outcome           | Lower | Upper | Missing | N   |
|------|-------------------|-------|-------|---------|-----|
| 2012 | Graduate or above | -16.4 | 18.9  | 46      | 272 |
| 2012 | Any pending case  | -33.9 | -6.1  | 35      | 272 |
| 2017 | Graduate or above | -2.5  | 6.3   | 10      | 272 |
| 2017 | Any pending case  | -11.5 | -7.5  | 5       | 272 |
| 2022 | Graduate or above | -5.0  | -0.1  | 6       | 250 |
| 2022 | Any pending case  | -21.3 | -19.9 | 2       | 250 |

## D Published comparisons

**Table D.1:** Published comparisons of leader qualifications

| Study                                                                       | Setting                                                                            | Design                                          | Outcome                                | Reserved | Open  | Difference (SE)          | N     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|----------|-------|--------------------------|-------|
| <i>Elected village leaders, women-reserved vs. open seats</i>               |                                                                                    |                                                 |                                        |          |       |                          |       |
| Chattopadhyay and Duflo (2001)<br><i>Table 3, panels A and B</i>            | West Bengal (Birbhum);<br>1998 term; GP pradhan                                    | Randomized rotation                             | Years of schooling (years)             | 7.13     | 9.92  | −2.79 (0.54)             | 161   |
|                                                                             |                                                                                    |                                                 | Literate (%)                           | 80.0     | 98.0  | −19.0 (4.0)              | 161   |
|                                                                             |                                                                                    |                                                 | Elected to GP council before 1998 (%)  | 11.0     | 43.0  | −32.0 (7.0)              | 161   |
| Beaman et al. (2009)<br><i>Table II, column 6, printed p. 1507</i>          | West Bengal (Birbhum);<br>2003 term; GP pradhan                                    | Randomized rotation;<br>adjusted                | Years of schooling (years)             |          |       | −2.104 (0.548)           | 165   |
|                                                                             |                                                                                    |                                                 | First time as pradhan in 2003 term (%) |          |       | 26.5 (6.8)               | 165   |
|                                                                             |                                                                                    |                                                 | Other political experience (%)         |          |       | −12.1 (7.9)              | 165   |
| Ban and Rao (2007)<br><i>Table 8 (means), Table 9 column 2 (difference)</i> | Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu; 2002 survey; GP president           | Rotation; caste-reserved GPs excluded; adjusted | Years of schooling (years)             | 6.074    | 8.456 | −2.620 (0.766)           | 106   |
|                                                                             |                                                                                    |                                                 | Political knowledge score              | 3.185    | 4.608 | −1.413 (0.292)           | 106   |
|                                                                             |                                                                                    |                                                 | Prior political positions (count)      |          |       | −0.461 (0.188)           | 106   |
| Deininger et al. (2011)<br><i>Table 3, printed p. 22</i>                    | National (REDS, 233 villages); Up to three elections; REDS 2007 survey; GP pradhan | Descriptive                                     | Illiterate (%)                         | 24.7     | 5.7   | 19.0 (3.4) <sup>†</sup>  | 639   |
|                                                                             |                                                                                    |                                                 | At least secondary education (%)       | 28.6     | 62.7  | −34.0 (4.1) <sup>†</sup> | 639   |
|                                                                             |                                                                                    |                                                 | Held political office before (%)       | 11.7     | 24.2  | −12.6 (3.1) <sup>†</sup> | 639   |
| Afridi, Iversen and Sharan (2013)<br><i>Table 2, panel I, printed p. 38</i> | Andhra Pradesh (8 districts); In office 2006–10; GP sarpanch                       | Descriptive                                     | Illiterate (%)                         | 9.0      | 0.0   | 9.0 (2.2)                | 297   |
|                                                                             |                                                                                    |                                                 | Higher secondary or more (%)           | 15.0     | 54.0  | −40.0 (5.2)              | 297   |
|                                                                             |                                                                                    |                                                 | Own prior political experience (%)     | 11.0     | 22.0  | −11.0 (4.4)              | 297   |
| Bamezai et al. (2026)<br><i>Table 7, panel B</i>                            | Bihar; 2016 and 2021 elections; Mukhiya                                            | Fuzzy RD at population threshold; adjusted      | Schooling, SD of all citizens          |          |       | −0.921 (0.073)           | 3,294 |
| <i>Elected leaders, reserved women vs. men in other seats</i>               |                                                                                    |                                                 |                                        |          |       |                          |       |
| Raabe, Sekher and Birner (2009)<br><i>Table 4</i>                           | Karnataka (12 districts); 2006 survey; GP president                                | Descriptive                                     | Illiterate (%)                         | 9.0      | 4.0   | 5.0 (6.6) <sup>†</sup>   | 71    |

Table D.1 (continued)

| Study                                                                  | Setting                                                                    | Design                                     | Outcome                                                                                                                              | Reserved | Open | Difference (SE)          | N      |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|------|--------------------------|--------|
|                                                                        |                                                                            |                                            | Degree or above (%)                                                                                                                  | 0.0      | 19.0 | −19.0 (5.7) <sup>†</sup> | 71     |
| <i>Elected village leaders, women vs. men (conditional comparison)</i> |                                                                            |                                            |                                                                                                                                      |          |      |                          |        |
| Gajwani and Zhang (2015)<br><i>Table 5, column 6, p. 248</i>           | Tamil Nadu (144 GPs); 2005; GP president                                   | OLS; adjusted                              | Panchayat knowledge (0–19)                                                                                                           |          |      | −3.199 (0.474)           | 141    |
| <i>Municipal councillors, women-reserved vs. open seats</i>            |                                                                            |                                            |                                                                                                                                      |          |      |                          |        |
| Karekurve-Ramachandra and Lee (2020)<br><i>Table 1, printed p. 14</i>  | Mumbai; 2011–2018 (2012 and 2017 terms); Municipal councillor              | Descriptive                                | Attended university (%)                                                                                                              | 43.7     | 39.0 | 4.7 (2.9) <sup>†</sup>   | 1,118  |
|                                                                        |                                                                            |                                            | Criminal record (%)                                                                                                                  | 3.7      | 30.3 | −26.6 (2.1) <sup>†</sup> | 1,118  |
| <i>Candidates, women-reserved vs. open seats</i>                       |                                                                            |                                            |                                                                                                                                      |          |      |                          |        |
| Mori et al. (2022)<br><i>Table 3, panel B, column 1</i>                | Karnataka (Kolar, Tumkur); December 2020 election; GP member (single-seat) | Random rotation; adjusted                  | Education position among all villagers                                                                                               |          |      | −0.41 (0.33)             | 97     |
| Bamezai et al. (2026)<br><i>Table 7, panel A</i>                       | Bihar; 2016 and 2021 elections; Mukhiya                                    | Fuzzy RD at population threshold; adjusted | Schooling, SD of all citizens                                                                                                        |          |      | −0.765 (0.024)           | 44,583 |
| <i>Elected leaders, other benchmarks</i>                               |                                                                            |                                            |                                                                                                                                      |          |      |                          |        |
| Mori et al. (2022)<br><i>Table 3, panel B, column 3</i>                | Karnataka (Kolar, Tumkur); December 2020 election; GP member (single-seat) | Random rotation; adjusted                  | Education position among same-gender villagers<br><i>Reserved winner's position among women vs. open winner's position among men</i> |          |      | 0.74 (0.44)              | 92     |
| Bamezai et al. (2026)<br><i>Table 7, panel B</i>                       | Bihar; 2016 and 2021 elections; Mukhiya                                    | Fuzzy RD at population threshold; adjusted | Schooling, SD of same-gender citizens<br><i>Reserved winner's position among women vs. open winner's position among men</i>          |          |      | −0.619 (0.074)           | 3,249  |
|                                                                        |                                                                            |                                            | Husband's schooling, SD of all citizens<br><i>Reserved winner's husband vs. open-seat winner</i>                                     |          |      | −0.364 (0.089)           | 3,058  |

Reserved and Open are group means; shares are in percent. Difference is reserved minus open, in the outcome's unit (percentage points for shares), with its standard error in parentheses. Adjusted differences come from the study's regression and need not equal the difference in means. A dagger marks an SE not reported by the study: computed from shares and group sizes as for independent samples, or from the reported t-statistic; these ignore clustering and repeated units. N is the number of reserved plus open units where reported separately, otherwise the regression sample. SD rows are standardized against the GP's citizens; selection-score rows measure position in the villager education distribution. Chattopadhyay and Duflo (2001) and Beaman et al. (2009) study the same Birbhum GPs in successive terms; the published version of Chattopadhyay and Duflo (2004) omits the pradhan-characteristics table. Karekurve-Ramachandra and Lee (2020) use the same Mumbai councillor data as this paper. Mori et al.'s published version (2025) reports the same-gender benchmark. Row-level source locations and transcription notes are in the repository's evidence/literature/studies files. Gajwani and Zhang's adjusted female-minus-male knowledge coefficient is excluded from the schooling meta-analysis; group means are unavailable.